that charge at Herzliya, and he elaborated on it, warning that Netanyahu's government was "eroding democracy" in Israel. "A hostile takeover has occurred," he said. "The right-wing government, especially in the past year, is no longer walking in the footsteps of Ze'ev Jabotinsky and Menachem Begin. A fanatic core with radical ideology has taken over the Likud." He went on to warn that the government's "radical, dangerous agenda" was "endangering the future of the entire Zionist project."

A central piece of his criticism, of course, was Netanyahu's failure to take bold steps to resolve the conflict with the Palestinians. Two years earlier, in a private meeting with business executives, the Mossad chief told them that it was the Palestinians, and not Iran, who posed the greatest strategic threat to Israel.[11] It was an embarrassment to Netanyahu, who had spent years arguing the exact opposite. (It wasn't the last time Tamir Pardo would humiliate his boss. A few months later, he warned a group of US senators not to impose new economic sanctions on Iran, saying it would "throw a hand grenade" into the delicate nuclear negotiations.)

But the prime minister stuck to his argument. In late 2015, when he addressed the Knesset's foreign affairs and defense committee, he explained that—while he did not want Israel to become a binational state—he saw no solution in the near future. "You think there is a magic wand here, but I disagree," he told opposition lawmakers. "I'm asked if we will forever live by the sword: yes."

Barak once dressed up as a woman to sneak into Beirut and kill PLO members. Yitzhak Rabin oversaw the ethnic cleansing of Lydda (now Lod). Ariel Sharon's military activities sparked international outrage. Yet all of them eventually decided that it was essential for Israel to make peace with the Palestinians, and that doing so would require Israel to relinquish territory. Even setting aside morals and geopolitics, there was a sound military logic for doing so. A two-state solution would make the army's job immeasurably easier. It could get out of the business of occupation—the checkpoints, the nightly raids, the endless clashes at Qalandia and Bil'in. It could focus its resources on defending a clearly-demarcated border, instead of devoting thousands of soldiers to protect a few hundred settlers living amidst a hostile Palestinian population. The peace process may not be an issue for most Israeli voters, but it remains a point of major friction between the army and the right-wing government.